

ACING THE BEHAVIORAL INTERVIEW

In a behavioral interview, an employer is looking for a set of core competencies needed to succeed in the position. Some examples of these include teamwork, communication, problem-solving, and leadership skills. The premise of these questions is that past behavior is an indicator of future performance.

Behavioral questions usually start with the phrase “Tell me about a time when...” or “Can you give an example of a situation where...” For example, “Tell me about a challenge you faced and how you overcame it.”

SOME TYPICAL BEHAVIORAL QUESTIONS ASK ABOUT TIMES WHEN YOU:

- had to solve a problem
- helped a team to accomplish a goal
- had to know something about a topic and conduct research
- motivated a coworker or peer to work better
- made a mistake or experienced failure
- organized an event or project, and it did not go according to the original plan
- sought advice or feedback from someone
- had to deal with time constraints
- showed a great deal of initiative
- made a sacrifice for the betterment of the group
- helped or mentored someone
- had to give someone bad news
- encountered a challenging project
- dealt with an ethical dilemma
- had competing demands to fulfill and how you accomplished the results
- worked with a difficult teammate, coworker, or supervisor

The key to success with behavioral interviews is providing concrete examples and staying concise. Hiring managers often meet with 10+ candidates each day, and therefore you must present yourself in a way that holds their attention and makes you stand out from the competition.

The following two methods provide a helpful framework for responding to behavioral questions when you are asked to provide an example from your experience. You should only take about 2 minutes on each response, so be selective with the details shared. Focus on the most relevant details to the question asked – keep it simple.

STAR METHOD

Situation: Set the scene

- Where you were
- When this took place

Task: Identify what you were trying to achieve

- What did you have to do?
- Specifics of your role

Action: This will be the most significant piece of the response. Specifically, identify what steps you took.

- What you did
- Why you did it/purpose
- How you did it: skills used/qualities demonstrated
- If the action was with a team, be sure to mention but also highlight your specific role. Avoid the use of “we” here

Result: Close the question by stating an outcome to your situation or impact made

- What happened as a result of the action(s) you took
- What the impact of your actions was, or what difference you made
- What you learned from the experience
- What you would do differently or improve (if applicable)
- Quantify when possible



EXAMPLE

Question: Tell me about a time you worked successfully under pressure.

S: During summer 2021, I worked as a design intern for Datadog, a startup in New York City. I was partnering with the lead designer to reimagine the design of the company's products.

T: We were set to deliver our vision to the company leadership with a presentation, which I spent the last three weeks developing. On the evening before the presentation, the lead designer reached out that she had a family emergency and would be out the rest of the week.

A: While the lead designer offered to request a new presentation date, I told her I would move forward, knowing how important it was for company leadership to implement a new design. I spent the rest of that evening familiarizing myself more with her areas of the presentation. I then woke up early the following day to practice the presentation in its entirety.

R: I joined the five company leaders for their meeting and presented the new design options. The reaction to the new ideas was overwhelmingly positive, and I was able to answer questions from the leaders about implementation successfully. It was a great experience for me to take ownership of a project and gave me the confidence to communicate with senior employees in the future.

CAR METHOD

Challenge: Set the context

Action: Demonstrate what you did to improve the situation

Result: Show the outcome of the situation and/or impact you made

A helpful method to prepare for behavioral questions is to identify your top skill/strengths and brainstorm two corresponding STAR or CAR examples for each. These stories can then be used to answer a range of questions. Examples may be drawn from various experiences, including work, projects, volunteer/community service, extracurricular activities, and academics. Then, when you have the job description, use the qualifications listed there to determine which skills/strengths you should develop your examples around.

Practice using these methods by scheduling a **mock interview with a career adviser** and using [Big Interview](#), YU's online interview prep platform (make an account with your YU email address).

